may have once invoked those ideals. Now, there's another totem that speaks the narratives. Tarn Taran is part of the Khadoor Sahib Lok Sabha seat. The one that shot to spotlight in 2024 when Amritpal Singh, the Khalistani propagandist booked under NSA, won the election from behind bars.

PANTHIC PANOPLY

All three candidates, to be sure, seek to strike the panthic chord. AAP's Sandhu, a three-time former MLA, is poached from SAD. Sukhbir Badal's party candidate, former school principal Sukhwinder Kaur Randhawa, is the wife of a 1984 army mutineer, a cohort known as *dharmi faujis* (soldiers of faith). No doubts about her politics—she had supported Amritpal in 2024. But then, the genuine article is on offer too: Mandeep Singh, backed by Amritpal's Waris Punjab De.

Amritpal's 2024 win, by a mammoth margin of nearly 200,000 votes, had stated without ambiguity where Khadoor Sahib's preferences lie. Tarn Taran itself had gone towards a more modernist line in 2022, choosing Kashmir Singh Sohal, a career doctor. But his untimely death in June 2025 has yanked it back to a threshold where rational issues like governance must contest with the aggravated emotions faith evokes.

Tarn Taran's 170,000 electorate is 78 per cent rural, and its nearly 65 per cent Sikh bloc has a decisive Dalit Sikh segment that swings between AAP and Congress. AAP mopped up 48 per cent of the vote in 2022, reducing SAD to a sad 16 per cent, but its aura has waned amid perceived bureaucratic lethargy and law-and-order concerns. The Congress, with a steady base among rural Jat Sikhs and Dalits, sees Tarn Taran as its comeback chance. Its threat: the BJP snatching urban Hindu and rural Dalit votes. The result comes on November 14, three days after voting.

Punjab is gradually warming up for the 2027 assembly poll. This bypoll will feed the narrative, deciding who owns the panthic vote. SAD is striving to reclaim its old turf with renewed posturing. It could have been more sanguine but for the hardliners, who have pushed the envelope. Mandeep exemplifies that. His brother, Sandeep Singh, is accused of the 2023 broad daylight murder of Hindu activist Sudhir Suri in Amritsar. In September, he made news again—this time allegedly killing a former cop and injuring two others in Patiala jail, all accused of extra-judicial encounters in Tarn Taran in 1993 and, as luck would have it, in the same jail.

Soon, Ranjit Singh Damdami Taksal, chief of the Sikh Youth Federation (Bhindranwale), reportedly persuaded Mandeep to contest. Waris Punjab De endorsed him. The high-decibel campaign, featuring images of slain and jailed Sikh terrorists, has activated a beehive of hardliners. Thus was an MLA born? If Tarn Taran chooses. ■

Takeaways

- **The Tarn Taran bypoll, on Nov. 11, pits the traditional parties against radicals**
- **Amritpal's Waris Punjab De backs Mandeep, the brother of a jailed Sikh militant**
- **The Akali Dal is seeking to reclaim its old turf, but is up against a faith-led narrative**
- **AAP rests its hopes on an ex-Akali, Congress seeks to hold base against BJP ingress**



▶ J&K

UPPER HOU

Omar, still shy of statehood dream,

By **Kaleem Geelani**

RAMESHWAR SINGH, THE MLA FROM BANI in Jammu & Kashmir's Kathua district, spoke in a conspiratorial tone. "I'm in hiding, not telling anyone where I am. This attention is rare and joyful," he told INDIA TODAY. "I'm not giving my vote away too easy, without conditions and commitments to my constituency." Singh, the lone Independent MLA from Jammu, was feeling a rare surge of importance, like his peers in the year-old assembly. The province had a renewed tryst with Rajya Sabha elections on October 24, for four seats lying vacant since February 2021—and both sides were seeking his favours. The unsung MLA was at last in demand!

In the end, the ruling National Con-